PRACTITIONER WELLNESS GUIDE

Pour From Wholeness

A practitioner wellness guide for helpers, healers, and the people who hold everyone else

BUILD & BLOOM COLLECTIVE

INSIDE

Contents

01 Start here

02 Know your signs

03 The Capacity Check

04 Recovery between sessions

05 Protect your caseload and calendar

06 Your support map

07 For practice owners and team leads

08 Your 30-day Restore Plan

01

Start here

You became a helper because you care. This guide is about caring for the person who does the caring.

It is for therapists, counselors, social workers, coaches, nurses, peer specialists, faith and community leaders, and anyone whose work means holding other people's hard moments. It is also for practice owners who want a team that lasts.

Work through it with a pen. Each section has something to notice, something to try, and something to write down. You do not need to do it all at once. Pick the page you need this week.

> Pour from wholeness, not depletion. Rest is not a reward for finishing the work. It is part of how the work gets done well.

A note before you begin. This guide is general education, not therapy or medical advice. If you are struggling, reach out to your own therapist, doctor, or supervisor. If you are in crisis or thinking about harming yourself, call or text 988 (the Suicide & Crisis Lifeline in the U.S.) or go to your nearest emergency room.

02

Know your signs

Helpers often notice everyone's exhaustion but their own. Naming what you feel is the first step to changing it. These four terms overlap, and you can have more than one at once.

WHAT IT IS	WHAT IT CAN FEEL LIKE	WHAT USUALLY HELPS
Burnout: exhaustion from chronic work stress that has not been managed. It is about the workload and conditions, not your character.	Running on empty, dreading the schedule, feeling cynical or detached, doubting your effectiveness	Changing the load and the structure: caseload, schedule, boundaries, support
Compassion fatigue: the emotional and physical cost of caring for people who are suffering	Less patience, numbness, feeling like you have nothing left to give	Recovery time, peer support, reconnecting with meaning
Secondary traumatic stress: trauma-like reactions from hearing about others' trauma	Intrusive images from sessions, being on edge, avoiding certain clients or topics	Supervision or consultation, grounding practices, your own therapy
Vicarious trauma: slow shifts in how you see the world after long exposure to others' pain	Feeling the world is unsafe, losing trust, changes in your sense of hope	Ongoing support, balance in your caseload, meaning-making

SIGNS TO WATCH FOR

- [ ] I feel tired even after a day off
- [ ] I dread opening my calendar or email
- [ ] I am more irritable or numb than I used to be
- [ ] Sessions or stories replay in my mind after hours
- [ ] I have stopped doing things that used to restore me
- [ ] I cancel my own appointments, but never a client's
- [ ] I feel less effective, or wonder if I am still good at this
- [ ] My sleep, appetite, or body is telling me something

If you checked several of these, you are not failing. You are carrying too much without enough support. The rest of this guide is about changing that.

03

The Capacity Check

Take five minutes. Rate each statement from 1 (not at all) to 5 (very true right now). This is a reflection tool, not a diagnosis.

AREA	STATEMENT	YOUR SCORE (1 TO 5)
Body	I sleep, eat, and move in ways that support me most days.	
Boundaries	My work hours and caseload have clear limits that I keep.	
Recovery	I have time to reset between sessions and after hard days.	
Support	I have supervision, consultation, or peers I can talk to honestly.	
Meaning	I still feel connected to why I do this work.	
Life	I have relationships and joy outside of my work.	

WHAT YOUR SCORES TELL YOU

- **Mostly 4s and 5s:** your foundation is strong. Protect it, especially in busy seasons.
- **Mostly 3s:** you are holding steady, but one hard month could tip you. Choose one area to strengthen this month.
- **Any 1s or 2s:** start there. Your lowest score is your growing edge, and small changes there make the biggest difference.

MY LOWEST AREA IS

ONE SMALL THING I CAN CHANGE IN THAT AREA THIS WEEK IS

04

Recovery between sessions

You do not need an hour of self-care to recover. You need small, repeatable resets built into the day. Try one practice at a time until it becomes automatic.

THE 4-6 BREATH (1 MINUTE)

Breathe in through your nose for a count of 4. Breathe out slowly for a count of 6. Repeat three to five times. A longer exhale helps your body shift out of high alert.

A TRANSITION RITUAL (2 MINUTES)

Between clients, give your body a signal that one session has ended and the next has not begun.

1. Stand up and stretch, or step outside.
2. Wash your hands or splash cool water on your face, and imagine letting the last session go.
3. Say the next person's name and one thing you want to bring to them.

GROUNDING WHEN A SESSION STAYS WITH YOU (2 MINUTES)

Name 5 things you can see, 4 you can touch, 3 you can hear, 2 you can smell, and 1 you can taste. It brings your attention back to the room you are in.

THE END-OF-DAY CLOSE (5 MINUTES)

- [ ] Write down anything still on your mind, so it lives on paper instead of in your head
- [ ] Note one moment from today that mattered
- [ ] Close your notes and your laptop, and say "done for today"
- [ ] Do one thing that marks the shift home: change clothes, take a walk, play a song

> Pick one practice. Use it every day for two weeks before adding another.

05

Protect your caseload and calendar

Most burnout is a structure problem. The fastest relief usually comes from changing how your week is built, not from trying harder to cope with it.

BUILD THESE INTO YOUR WEEK

- [ ] A daily session limit you decide in advance, and keep
- [ ] At least 10 to 15 minutes between sessions
- [ ] A protected block for notes and admin, so they do not spill into your evenings
- [ ] One lighter day, or a half day with no sessions
- [ ] A cap on new intakes each week, with a waitlist when you are full

BOUNDARY SCRIPTS YOU CAN USE

WHEN	YOU CAN SAY
Someone asks for an after-hours session	"My last session is at 6. The earliest I can offer is Tuesday at 10."
You are asked to take one more client	"I want to give my current clients my best, so I am not taking new clients right now. I can add you to my waitlist or share a referral."
A message arrives at night	"Thank you for your message. I respond during business hours, Monday to Friday. If this is an emergency, call 988 or 911."
You need to end a session on time	"We are coming to the end of our time. Let's hold onto this and start here next week."

MY WEEK, REBUILT

MY LIMIT	WHAT I WILL SET IT TO
Sessions per day	
Protected admin time	
My lighter day	

06

Your support map

Helpers need help too. Strong support has more than one source, so no one person or practice has to hold everything.

FILL IN YOUR MAP

KIND OF SUPPORT	WHO OR WHAT IT IS FOR ME	HOW OFTEN
Clinical supervision or consultation		
Peer support (people who do this work)		
My own therapy or counseling		
Body care (doctor, movement, rest)		
Spirit and meaning (faith, nature, creativity)		
People who know me outside of work		

QUESTIONS TO BRING TO SUPERVISION OR CONSULTATION

- Which client or case is staying with me the most right now?
- Where am I working harder than my client?
- What am I avoiding, and why?
- What would I tell a colleague who described my week to me?

> If a row on your map is empty, that is your next step. Ask one colleague about a peer consultation group, or schedule your own appointment this month.

07

For practice owners and team leads

When a whole team is tired, it is rarely about individual resilience. It is about how the work is set up. Leaders can change that.

SEVEN PLACES TO LOOK

AREA	THE QUESTION TO ASK
Workload & Capacity	Does the amount of work fit the people and hours we have?
Recovery & Scheduling	Do schedules leave room to recover from demanding sessions?
Support & Supervision	Does everyone get consistent support, especially after hard days?
Role Clarity & Workflows	Do our processes and tools make the work easier, or harder?
Psychological Safety & Belonging	Can people speak up, ask for help, and be fully themselves?
Leadership & Communication	Are decisions and changes shared clearly and fairly?
Purpose & Growth	Does the work still feel meaningful, with room to grow?

START WITH THESE

- [ ] Ask your team, anonymously, which part of the week drains them most
- [ ] Add a short debrief after crisis calls or especially hard sessions
- [ ] Make caseload limits a policy, not a personal negotiation
- [ ] Protect admin time on every clinician's schedule
- [ ] Put supervision on the calendar, and keep it even in busy weeks
- [ ] Model it yourself: take your time off and leave on time

Build & Bloom's Organizational Wellness Assessment looks at all seven areas with an anonymous team survey, then turns the results into a plan. Ask about it in your portal.

08

Your 30-day Restore Plan

Small, steady changes last longer than big resets. Check off each step as you go.

WEEK 1: NOTICE

- [ ] Take the Capacity Check and circle your lowest area
- [ ] Choose one recovery practice and use it every workday
- [ ] Write down your current daily session count and work hours

WEEK 2: PROTECT

- [ ] Set your daily session limit and your protected admin block
- [ ] Use one boundary script from this guide
- [ ] Put one full day of rest on your calendar for the next 30 days

WEEK 3: CONNECT

- [ ] Fill in your support map
- [ ] Book supervision, consultation, or your own appointment
- [ ] Reach out to one person who restores you

WEEK 4: SUSTAIN

- [ ] Retake the Capacity Check and compare your scores
- [ ] Keep what worked, and let go of what did not
- [ ] Choose your focus for the next 30 days

WHAT CHANGED FOR ME THIS MONTH

> If your scores are not improving, or if you are feeling hopeless, numb, or unsafe, that is a sign to get more support, not to push harder. Talk with your own therapist or doctor. In a crisis, call or text 988.